

RAJASTHAN
Surabhi Pareek, 22, *B.Sc. (Biology), B.Ed. (Final year)*

Job applied for: Senior secondary teacher
Total vacancies: 31,000; Total applications: 1.6 million

Bikaner resident Surabhi topped the Rajasthan Eligibility Exam for Teachers (REET) Level 2 for senior secondary posts in government schools. For just 31,000 jobs, 1.6 million candidates took the test conducted by the Rajasthan Board of School Education in September 2021. Being the topper turned out to be a nightmare as she was trolled on social media for cheating and started getting abusive calls. In February, CM Ashok Gehlot cancelled the examination amid allegations that around 300 candidates had access to the leaked paper.

The cancellation has not just stymied Surabhi's hope for a government job, but also added another social pressure. "I am told that unless I make it to the top 10 again, it would mean I cheated last year," she says. Surabhi is also worried about other rank holders from poor and rural backgrounds who would have to bear the financial impact of going through the process again. Among them was a shepherd and another who had to sell off his mother's jewellery. "The media projected that a majority of the candidates wanted a re-exam. Obviously, 97 per cent who failed would want that," says Surabhi.

of ministries to hire or not. Only they can explain why they are not hiring," he told INDIA TODAY, when asked why two DoPT reminders to ministries—on January 21, 2020, and June 3, 2021—spurred none into action. Another DoPT official claims several ministries fail to formally cite their vacancies before budgetary provisions are made. Some bureaucrats blame it on recruiting organisations—and indeed, thereby hangs another tale.

Civilian recruitments to the central government are conducted primarily by four organisations—the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), which hires civil servants; the Staff Selection Commission (SSC), which recruits non-gazetted staff to Group 'C' (Class III) and Group 'B' posts; the RRB, which handles the railways; and the self-explanatory Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS). SSC and RRB have often been embroiled in controversies. In 2018, an alleged paper leak in an SSC exam led to a CBI probe. Curiously, between 2018 and 2020, the SSC recruited the lowest number of candidates, less than one-fourth of what it recruited in 2016-17 or in 2020-21. INDIA TODAY reached out to Ashim Khurana, then SSC chairman, but did not get any response.

RRB exams, too, have not escaped the taint of corruption. In 2010, the CBI unearthed a multi-crore railway recruitment scam and arrested eight persons, including the son of the Mumbai RRB chairman, for allegedly leaking exam papers. For experts, the recent Bihar incidents are only a symptom. "Why does it take over two years to announce these results? That speaks volumes about the government's attitude towards the massive job crisis in the country," says economist Santosh Mehrotra, former professor, Centre for Informal Sector and Labour Studies, JNU.

Barring a handful, most states don't have a singular recruiting agency. Most departments hold their own exams or outsource it to private agencies. Not surprisingly, these often get mired in allegations of malpractices and long legal battles. In February 2017, Bihar police arrested Bihar Staff Selection Commission (BSSC) chairman and senior IAS officer Sudhir Kumar as well as BSSC secretary Parmeshwar Ram for alleged involvement in a question paper leak in an exam to recruit clerks and